Anthropology 241M
Chinese Peoples and Cultures. . .
or . . . Introduction to Chinese Civilization, from Antiquity to Present

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I. INTRODUCTION AND OBJECTIVES

"...understanding a people's culture exposes their normalness without reducing their particularity...It renders them accessible: setting them in the frame of their own banalities, it dissolves their opacity" [Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures*, p. 14 (New York: 1973)].

It is our objective in this course to examine some of the important facets of Chinese culture, both traditional and contemporary. With a history as long and as rich as China's, we will only be able to scratch the surface of several facets of Chinese civilization, with the hope that these introductory explorations will encourage you to further your study of China, either formally or informally.

II. MATERIALS

• Conrad Schirokauer, *A Brief History of Chinese Civilization* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace Gap College, 1991).

• supplementary readings—a small fee will be assessed at the beginning of the course to cover copying costs

strongly recommended: Booth, Colomb and Williams, *The Craft of Research* (Chicago: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1995). If you feel you have not yet mastered the art of writing a research paper, this is the book for you. It walks you through the process step by step. I urge you to purchase this book. The bookstore will have this book as an optional title for this class. If they run out, it can also be obtained through Amazon.com (www.amazon.com) for $10.40 plus shipping and handling.

III. CLASS REQUIREMENTS

• *Attendance*: Attendance is mandatory. Any absences must be excused

in advance. **Each unexcused absence will lower your final grade by two percentage points**. Please do not be tardy. **Each late arrival to class will lower your final grade by one percentage point**. As an incentive to attend class and be on time, I will add two percentage points to your final grade if you have no absences (excused or unexcused) or tardies during the entire semester.

• *Class preparation:* Always come to class prepared for the topic or discussion at hand. A rough schedule follows on this syllabus. Specific assignments and readings will be announced in class.

• *Assignments:* All assignments must be turned in on the due date as indicated on the syllabus or as announced in class. Late assignments will NOT be accepted.

- **Quizzes**: There will be a few short quizzes, some announced, some unannounced. These will cover specific things you will be required to memorize, readings, etc. Nothing to lose sleep over.
- **Research paper**: 12-15 pages, a list of suggested topics follows. **Note the deadlines for proposals and drafts in the following schedule**.
- **Presentation**: 5-10 minutes—the sky's the limit on this one. In lieu of a final exam, I ask you to prepare some type of a presentation which will be given during the final exam period. **Consultation with the instructor is required early in the semester to plan this project**. This doesn't necessarily have to be a "talk." I encourage the use of technology—don't rule out creating a website that would be unveiled during the presentation period, a slide-illustrated discussion of some artwork, etc.

As you can see, there is not a lot of written work required in this class. Due to this fact, I expect extremely high quality on the paper, presentation and participation.

IV. ASSIGNMENTS AND GRADING

- Quizzes: 10%
- Participation: 40%
- Paper: 25%
- Presentation: 25%
- Scale:

93–100%	A
90–92%	A-
87–89%	B+
83–86%	B
80–82%	B-
77–79%	C+

73–76%	C
70–72%	C-
67–69%	D+
63–66%	D
60–62%	D-
0–59%	F

V. GENERAL

- If you are in need of assistance, see the instructor for help. Please make an appointment and try to identify your specific problem before you come.
- The instructor will make every reasonable effort to accommodate students with special handicaps. Please inform him of any special needs during the first week of class.
- In response to health, death or other unforeseen circumstances, the instructor reserves the right to make changes to the syllabus during the course of the semester.

SCHEDULE:

1/6 Introduction (Galer; film: "Overview of Chinese History")

1/8 Geography (Galer, film: "Man and Nature")

1/11 Geography (Galer, film: "Peasant Life in China")

1/13 Geography/Food (Galer, film: "Food and Feasting in China")

1/15 Language and Culture (Galer)

1/20 Society—Family (Su, film: "Social Organization in China")

1/22 Society—Interpersonal Relations and Women (Su, film: "Marriage and the Chinese Family")

1/25 Society—Education, Minorities (Su)

1/27 Prehistory/Archaeology (Galer)

- Read *A Brief History of Chinese Civilization* (hereafter BH) chapter 1

1/29 Bronzes (Su)

2/1 Confucian Philosophy in Thought and Government (Su)

- Read BH ch. 2

2/3 Literature: The *Shijing* and *Chuci* (Su)

2/5 The Scholar Official (Galer)

2/8 Taoism and Legalism (Galer, film: "Introduction to Traditional Chinese Beliefs")

- Review BH pp. 42–49

2/10 More Taoism (Galer)

2/12 Unification and Bureaucratization: The Qin and Han (Su)

- Read BH ch. 3
- **PAPER PROPOSAL DUE (including annotated bibliography of at least 7 sources)**

2/17 Sima Qian and the *Shiji* (Galer)

2/19 Transportation and Economy (Su)

2/22 Buddhism in China (Galer, film?)
- Read BH ch. 4

2/24 Chinese Inventions and Gifts to the West (Galer, film: "Traditional Chinese Science")

2/26 China's Golden Age: The Tang (Su)
- Read BH ch. 5
- **QUIZ ON DYNASTIC PERIODS**

3/1 FILM: "China's Cosmopolitan Age: The Tang"

3/3 Literature: Tang Poetry (Galer)
- Read handout
- **PRESENTATION PROPOSAL DUE (including proposed format and sources)**

3/5 Traditional Chinese Music (Su)

3/8 History of the Song/Yuan/Ming (Su, film: "China: the Restoration (Ming)")
- Read BH chs. 6–8

3/10 Chinese Painting (Su)
- **DRAFT 1 OF PAPER DUE**

3/12 China in the 1800s: Crisis in Ecology and Population (Galer)
- Read BH chs. 9–10

3/15 China in the 1800s: The Coming of the West (Galer)
- Read BH chs. 11–12

3/17 Revolutionary China: Peasants in the 1900s (Galer)

3/19 Revolutionary China: Defining a New China (Galer)
- Read BH chs. 13–14

3/22 Literature: Lu Xun (Su)

3/24 The Rise of the Communist Party (Su)
- Read BH ch. 15

3/26 FILM: *China in Revolution* (1911–1949)

3/29 *China in Revolution* continued

3/31 History of the Communist Period (Su)
- Read BH ch. 16 pp. 351–364

4/5 FILM: *The Mao Years* (1949–1979)

4/7 *The Mao Years* continued
- **FINAL DRAFT OF PAPER DUE**

4/9 The Cultural Revolution (Su)
- Read BH ch. 16 pp. 365–end

4/12 FILM: *The Gate of Heavenly Peace*

4/14 *The Gate of Heavenly Peace*

4/16 Brief introduction to modern Chinese cinema and FILM: *To Live*

4/19 *To Live*

4/21 **12:30 to 2:00 PM Final Presentations (Final presentation MUST be given at this time.)**

Possible Paper Topics

oracle bones
divination and the *Book of Changes* (I Ching)
ancestor worship
various gods, i.e. gods of nature, gods of the earth, gods of the house
doctors, diviners and magicians in early China
early shamanism
Chinese ideas of life and death
Chinese ceramics (ancient or contemporary)
the mystery and uses of jade
bronze technology and ornamentation
art and political expression in early China
Chinese cosmology
Confucianism and its affect on ancient and/or modern China
Neo-Confucianism
the origins of Chinese political philosophy
ancient Chinese music or the significance of music in ancient China
Taoism and Taoist arts
Taoist inspired poetry or painting
the philosophy of Zhuangzi
Chinese herbal medicine
first emperor and the unification of China
first emperor's tomb
popular songs and ballads of Han China
Sima Qian and the *Shiji* (Records of the Grand Historian)
examination system
landscape painting
Tang poetry or prose (you could pick one writer, a few, or a style)
the Silk Road
folk arts, i.e. popular theater or opera; street enterainment, etc.
Chinese festivals
Chinese gardens
women in pre-modern China; practice of footbinding
food in Chinese history
Chinese minorities (or just one)
Christians in China before the modern era
the Opium War
the Boxer Rebellion
May 4th literature (pick an author or authors)
rise of the communist party
contemporary Chinese music (Cui Jian?)
contemporary Chinese literature
the Yangtze River dam
human rights in China
family planning